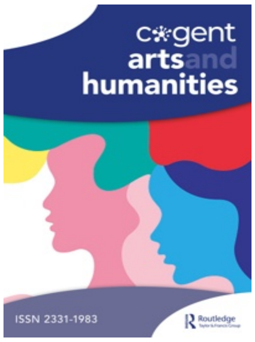

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Enhancing fans and artists' affective engagement and behavioral intentions in digital music streaming platforms through relational bonds: a case study of JOOX Rooms

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ABSTRACT

This study examines the role of relational bonds in enhancing fans' and artists' affective engagement and behavioral intentions on digital music streaming platforms. Specifically, we focus on JOOX Rooms, a live-streaming service that allows fans to interact with artists in real-time. Drawing on the Stimulus-Organism-Response (SOR) framework and relationship marketing literature, we investigate how the development of financial, social, and structural bonds between fans and artists impacts affective engagement and subsequent behavioral intentions. Survey data from 175 JOOX Rooms users in Thailand were analyzed using structural equation modeling. Results show that all three types of relational bonds positively influence affective engagement with the JOOX platform, which in turn predicts higher behavioral intentions to continue using and recommend the service. Notably, affective engagement with artists was empirically indistinguishable from platform engagement, suggesting that in this context, the platform itself becomes integral to the fan-artist relationship. These findings highlight the importance of relational bonds as key factors in promoting engagement and participation on digital music streaming platforms. Our study contributes to media ecology, fan studies, and platform studies by providing insights into the dynamics of relational bonds in digital media environments and their impact on user behavior.

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affective engagement; Digital music streaming; fan studies; JOOX Rooms; platform studies; relational bonds; SOR model

SUBJECTS
Identity; race; gender; technology; digital; data justice; surveillance; visual culture; time; space; health; media; popular culture; consumer culture

Introduction

The entertainment industry has transformed dramatically due to the proliferation of digital technologies. The development and implementation of new platforms, such as digital streaming services, have accelerated, introducing novel ways for fans to engage with their preferred artists. Contemporary music fans seek immersive digital experiences and desire exclusive access to artists' work, demanding deeper authenticity from entertainers through shared interests, connections, and memorable engagements (McHugh and Krieg, 2021; Hou et al., 2024). Artists and music brands seeking to remain competitive must develop innovative approaches to interact with fans in meaningful ways. The artist-fan relationship is fundamentally essential, with entertainers providing content and, in return, receiving support and revenue (Peltz, 2013). Fans hunger for intimate and authentic connections with entertainers to establish relationships that benefit both parties.

Digital streaming platforms such as JOOX Rooms play a dominant role in contemporary media consumption, a trend that accelerated significantly in the post-pandemic era (Hou et al., 2024). These platforms have created avenues for artists to monetize fan engagements through virtual performances and interactive features. Artists can earn approximately R 1500 from delivering a 30-minute virtual performance through the JOOX platform (Isaacs, 2020). Artists live-stream music and share their preferred

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songs to secure more fans, earning gifts and JOOX coins from followers. JOOX, often compared to Spotify in its music catalog, differentiates itself through a user interface specifically designed to enhance artist-fan engagement, positioning itself as a 'social entertainment platform' rather than merely a streaming service (Music Press Asia, 2017). JOOX has established dominance in key Asian markets, including Indonesia, Malaysia, and Thailand. Recent industry data indicates that streaming now accounts for 67% of global recorded music revenues, underscoring the critical importance of understanding user engagement on these platforms (IFPI, 2023). In Southeast Asia specifically, the digital music streaming market is projected to grow at an annual rate of 8.23% between 2024 and 2028, highlighting the region's increasing significance (Statista, 2024).

Vivek et al. (2012) describe consumer engagement as a crucial element of relationship marketing involving customer interaction with a brand's activities or offerings. The Marketing Science Institute has consistently identified consumer engagement as a key research priority, recognizing it as one of the fundamental challenges facing businesses in the digital age (Marketing Science Institute, 2022). Despite this acknowledged importance, empirical studies establishing effective approaches to improve consumer engagement remain relatively scarce, particularly in the rapidly evolving context of digital streaming platforms (Xia et al., 2024; Yum & Kim, 2024). Recent scholarship has called for more nuanced investigations into how platform-specific features and relational strategies drive engagement in entertainment contexts (Hou et al., 2024).

Digital streaming services such as JOOX depend on relational bonds—including discounted memberships, gaming rewards, special requests, and professional responses—to motivate fans to utilize interactive services (Bangkok Post, 2021). The concept of relational bonds is well-established in relationship marketing, introduced by Berry (1995) to connote varying degrees of relationship marketing comprising structural, social, and financial bonds. The use of relational bonds has become central in the entertainment industry as digital streaming operators seek to enhance consumer engagement. Based on the Stimulus-Organism-Response (SOR) framework, relational bonds function as stimuli that shape consumers' affective and cognitive states, ultimately determining behavioral responses. In the digital streaming context, behavioral intention (user participation) constitutes the response, affective consumer engagement represents the organism, and relational bonds serve as the stimuli.

This paper leverages the SOR framework to examine how relational bonds—structural, social, and financial, influence affective engagement between fans and artists in JOOX Rooms and subsequent behavioral intentions toward using the interactive platform. The study proposes that relational bonds enhance affective engagement, which in turn increases interaction levels, consumption, and intention to use JOOX Rooms. The case study of JOOX Rooms offers valuable insights for understanding how digital streaming platforms across regions utilize relational bonds to improve artist-fan relationships.

Research questions

Based on the theoretical framework outlined above, this study addresses the following research questions:

RQ1: How do financial, social, and structural bonds influence users' affective engagement with JOOX Rooms and with artists on the platform?

RQ2: How does affective engagement influence users' behavioral intentions toward continued use and recommendation of JOOX Rooms?

RQ3: Does affective engagement mediate the relationship between relational bonds and behavioral intentions?

Literature review

Stimulus-Organism-Response (SOR) model

The Stimulus-Organism-Response (SOR) framework, originally developed by Mehrabian and Russell (1974) in environmental psychology, provides the theoretical foundation for this study. The framework was subsequently refined for consumer behavior contexts by Jacoby (2002), who emphasized the importance of internal psychological processes in mediating the relationship between environmental inputs and behavioral outputs. The fundamental premise of the SOR model is that environmental elements serve as **stimuli (S)** that trigger an individual's internal emotional and cognitive states, the **organism (O)**, which in turn generate specific behavioral **responses (R)**.

The selection of the SOR framework for this study is justified on both theoretical and contextual grounds. Theoretically, the SOR model is particularly well-suited for investigating the mechanisms through which external marketing stimuli influence consumer outcomes because it explicitly accounts for the mediating role of internal psychological processes (Jacoby, 2002; Rasool et al., 2020). This is a critical advantage over simpler stimulus-response models, which treat the relationship between environmental inputs and behavioral outputs as direct and unmediated. In relationship marketing, the SOR framework allows researchers to explore *how* and *why* marketing efforts (such as relational bonds) translate into consumer engagement and loyalty, specifically by first shaping consumers' emotional and cognitive states.

Contextually, the SOR framework has been extensively and successfully applied to understand consumer behavior across digital environments, including online shopping (Chan et al., 2017), social commerce (Xia et al., 2024), live streaming platforms (Hou et al., 2024), and digital entertainment services (Yum & Kim, 2024). These studies consistently demonstrate that digital platform features and marketing stimuli influence user outcomes through their impact on users' internal states. For instance, Xia et al. (2024) found that social interaction cues on live streaming commerce platforms stimulated consumers' parasocial interactions and emotional trust, which in turn drove engagement and purchase intentions. Similarly, Hou et al. (2024) demonstrated that platform interactivity and reward systems on music live streaming services influenced user retention through emotional attachment.

While alternative theoretical frameworks exist—such as the Technology Acceptance Model (Davis, 1989), which focuses on perceived usefulness and ease of use, or Uses and Gratifications Theory (Katz et al., 1973), which emphasizes active audience choice, these frameworks are less suited to the present investigation. TAM is primarily utilitarian and cognitive, making it better equipped to explain adoption of productivity-oriented technologies than engagement with hedonic, emotionally-driven platforms like JOOX Rooms. Uses and Gratifications Theory, while valuable for understanding why audiences select certain media, does not provide a clear causal pathway from platform features to internal psychological states to behavioral outcomes, which is central to our research question.

Application of the SOR framework

In the context of this research, we map the SOR components to our study variables as follows:

- **Stimuli (S):** The stimuli are the three types of relational bonds—financial, social, and structural, that JOOX Rooms provides to facilitate fan-artist interactions. These bonds represent the external marketing and platform design elements that users encounter when engaging with the service.
- **Organism (O):** The organism component comprises users' internal affective states, which we conceptualize as *affective engagement*. Following Hollebeek et al. (2019), we define affective engagement as the emotional reactions and feelings that users develop toward a brand or product following interaction. In this study, we distinguish between two targets of affective engagement: engagement with the JOOX platform itself and engagement with the artists on the platform.
- **Response (R):** The response is users' behavioral intentions, specifically their intention to continue using JOOX Rooms and to recommend the platform to others. Behavioral intention is a well-established proxy for actual behavior in consumer research (Fishbein & Ajzen, 1975) and represents the ultimate outcome of interest for digital streaming platforms.

Based on this conceptual mapping, we propose that relational bonds influence users' behavioral intentions indirectly, through their impact on users' affective engagement. This mediated relationship is the central theoretical proposition of our study.

Relational bonds

Relational bonds fulfill an essential role in relationship marketing, with previous literature extensively cementing their role in determining customer loyalty, relationship quality, satisfaction, commitment, and consumer trust (Berry, 1995; Chen & Chiu, 2009; Huang et al., 2014; Nath & Mukherjee, 2012). Lin et al. (2003) found that relational bonds can be grouped empirically into three categories: structural, social, and financial bonds, with significant positive correlations with consumers' commitment and trust. The majority of existing literature focuses on these three variants.

Financial or economic bonds

Financial bonds refer to monetary incentives and special price offerings provided to consumers to initiate and maintain relationships (Berry, 1995). In the digital streaming sector, these bonds typically manifest as loyalty points, promotional prices, price discounts, and virtual currency systems. Prior research has established that financial motives play a crucial role in inducing consumer engagement, as saving money and receiving tangible rewards are primary drivers for customers to maintain brand relationships (Berry, 1995; Peltier & Westfall, 2000; Peterson, 1995; Van Doorn et al., 2010). Rohm et al. (2013) found that financial incentives significantly stimulate consumer engagement in digital environments, triggering more frequent interaction between customers and firms. More recent studies of live streaming platforms confirm that virtual currency systems and reward mechanisms enhance user participation and foster emotional attachment to platforms (Hou et al., 2024).

JOOX Rooms incorporates several concrete financial bond features designed to enhance user engagement. Users can purchase **JOOX Coins**—a virtual currency—to send gifts to artists during live broadcasts, creating a tangible exchange that benefits both parties. The platform offers **membership discount codes**, **special promotions for bulk coin purchases**, and **gaming rewards** that provide users with financial value for their continued participation. These mechanisms are theoretically expected to generate positive engagement because they: (1) provide immediate tangible value, (2) create a sense of investment in the platform, and (3) establish reciprocal obligations where users who receive rewards feel motivated to continue participating. When fans give coins or gifts to artists during live broadcasts, they experience a sense of contribution and connection that transcends passive consumption. Thus, financial bonds in JOOX Rooms are not merely transactional incentives but relational tools that foster deeper emotional engagement with both the platform and its artists.

Social bonds

Social bonds encompass the interpersonal connections and personalized interactions that develop between consumers and brands or service providers (Berry, 1995). These bonds are characterized by mutual understanding, friendship, recognition, and self-disclosure (Hollebeek et al., 2019; Van Doorn et al., 2010). In digital environments, social bonds are particularly important because they compensate for the lack of physical presence by creating what Horton and Wohl (1956) termed 'parasocial interactions,' the illusion of face-to-face relationships with media figures. Research has consistently demonstrated that such interactive experiences trigger high levels of customer engagement (Brodie et al., 2011; Hollebeek et al., 2019). Labrecque (2014) found that perceived interactivity and self-disclosure on social media platforms foster parasocial relationships, which in turn enhance loyalty and engagement. Fan studies scholarship emphasizes that these parasocial connections are central to contemporary fan culture, where emotional investment in artists drives consumption practices (Click & Scott, 2025).

JOOX Rooms is fundamentally designed to facilitate social bonds through its interactive live streaming architecture. During broadcasts, several specific features enable social bonding:

- **Real-time chat functionality** allows fans to type messages that artists can read and respond to during broadcasts, creating a sense of direct communication.
- **Artist responsiveness** to fan comments, questions, and requests demonstrates that artists are attending to individual fans, fostering feelings of recognition and personal connection.

- **Personalized interactions** such as artists wishing fans happy birthday or acknowledging special occasions create moments of intimate connection.
- **Music discovery through social interaction** as artists introduce new songs based on fan preferences, creating shared musical experiences.

These features are theoretically expected to enhance affective engagement because they satisfy fundamental human needs for social connection and recognition. When fans experience personalized attention from artists, they develop parasocial relationships characterized by feelings of intimacy and loyalty (Horton & Wohl, 1956; Labrecque, 2014). Moreover, the social interactions facilitated by the platform extend beyond artist-fan dyads to include fan communities, as users interact with each other in JOOX Rooms, creating a sense of belonging to a shared fan community (Baym, 2018). Thus, social bonds in JOOX Rooms operate through multiple mechanisms—artist recognition, community belonging, and shared experiences—to foster emotional engagement with both the artists and the platform that enables these connections.

Structural bonds

Structural bonds refer to value-added services and structural solutions that enhance the customer experience and create switching costs (Chen & Chiu, 2009; Hsieh et al., 2005). Unlike financial bonds which provide monetary value, or social bonds which provide interpersonal value, structural bonds provide functional and informational value that makes the service more useful, reliable, and trustworthy. These bonds include professional information provision, technical support, prompt problem resolution, and service reliability. Prior research has established that structural bonds build trust by reducing uncertainty and demonstrating the organization's commitment to customer satisfaction (Wongkitrungrueng & Assarut, 2020; Xiang et al., 2016). Chen and Chiu (2009) found that structural bonds in online environments improve shopping experiences, enhance trust, and lower feelings of uncertainty associated with a brand. Platform studies scholarship emphasizes that the technical infrastructure and governance of platforms shape user experiences and relationships (Gillespie, 2018; Plantin et al., 2018).

JOOX Rooms incorporates structural bonds through several platform features that enhance the quality and reliability of the user experience:

- **Professional artist responses**: Artists in JOOX Rooms are expected to answer fan questions professionally and knowledgeably, providing value beyond mere entertainment.
- **Technical support infrastructure**: Users receive prompt responses when they encounter problems or have complaints, demonstrating platform reliability.
- **Information curation**: Users receive useful, well-organized information about songs and artists that enhances their listening pleasure and music discovery.
- **Clear communication**: Users are clearly informed about songs, artists, and platform features, reducing confusion and enhancing usability.
- **Streaming quality and reliability**: The underlying technical infrastructure ensures consistent, high-quality streaming that users can depend on.

These structural features are theoretically expected to generate affective engagement because they build trust—a fundamental component of emotional attachment. When users experience professional, reliable service, they develop confidence in the platform and positive feelings toward it. Unlike financial bonds which may create transactional loyalty, structural bonds create trust-based loyalty that is more resistant to competitive offers. Furthermore, the informational value provided through curated content enhances users' music enjoyment, creating positive emotional associations with the platform. Platform studies research demonstrates that users develop emotional attachments to platforms themselves, not just the content or people accessed through them (Gillespie, 2018; Plantin et al., 2018). Thus, structural bonds in JOOX Rooms contribute to affective engagement by establishing the platform as a trustworthy, reliable, and value-adding part of users' music listening experience.

Conceptual definitions

To ensure clarity and consistency throughout this study, we provide explicit definitions of key constructs as shown in Table 1.

Hypotheses development

Based on the theoretical foundations outlined above and the specific characteristics of the JOOX Rooms platform, we now formally develop the hypotheses guiding this study. Following the SOR framework, we propose that relational bonds (stimuli) influence behavioral intentions (response) through the mediating mechanism of affective engagement (organism).

Financial bonds and affective engagement

Financial bonds provide tangible value and create reciprocal obligations between users and platforms. Prior research demonstrates that financial incentives stimulate consumer engagement in digital environments (Rohm et al., 2013; Van Doorn et al., 2010). Recent live streaming studies confirm that virtual currency systems enhance user participation and foster emotional attachment (Hou et al., 2024). JOOX Rooms features such as JOOX Coins, membership discounts, and gaming rewards provide users with financial value, creating positive emotional associations. Therefore:

> **H1:** Financial bonds positively influence users' affective engagement with (a) JOOX Rooms and (b) artists on the platform.

Social bonds and affective engagement

Social bonds fulfill fundamental needs for connection and recognition through interpersonal interaction. Parasocial interaction theory suggests that fans develop emotional attachments to media figures through perceived intimacy (Horton & Wohl, 1956; Labrecque, 2014). Fan studies research emphasizes that these parasocial connections are central to fan culture and consumption practices (Click & Scott, 2025). JOOX Rooms features such as real-time chat, artist responsiveness, and personalized interactions create opportunities for parasocial relationship development. Therefore:

> **H2:** Social bonds positively influence users' affective engagement with (a) JOOX Rooms and (b) artists on the platform.

Structural bonds and affective engagement

Structural bonds build trust by providing reliable, professional service and reducing uncertainty. Trust is a fundamental component of emotional attachment (Wongkitrungrueng & Assarut, 2020; Xiang et al.,

Table 1. Construct definitions.

Construct	Definition	Source
Financial Bonds	Monetary incentives and special price offerings provided to consumers to initiate and maintain relationships, including loyalty points, discounts, and virtual currency.	Berry (1995); Hsieh et al. (2005)
Social Bonds	Interpersonal connections and personalized interactions between consumers and brands/service providers, characterized by mutual understanding, friendship, and recognition.	Berry (1995); Hollebeek et al. (2019)
Structural Bonds	Value-added services and structural solutions that enhance customer experience and create switching costs, including professional information, technical support, and service reliability.	Chen and Chiu (2009); Hsieh et al. (2005)
Affective Engagement	The emotional reactions and feelings that users develop toward a brand, product, or person following interaction, including trust, attachment, and enjoyment.	Hollebeek et al. (2019); Vivek et al. (2012)
Behavioral Intentions	Users' self-reported likelihood of continuing to use a platform and recommending it to others; a well-established proxy for actual behavior in consumer research.	Fishbein and Ajzen (1975); Kumar et al. (2019)

2016). Platform studies scholarship demonstrates that users develop emotional attachments to platforms themselves through reliable infrastructure (Gillespie, 2018; Plantin et al., 2018). JOOX Rooms features such as professional responses, technical support, and information curation build trust and reliability. Therefore:

H3: Structural bonds positively influence users' affective engagement with (a) JOOX Rooms and (b) artists on the platform.

Affective engagement and behavioral intentions

Affective engagement encompasses trust, attachment, and enjoyment toward a brand or product. Prior research consistently demonstrates that emotionally engaged customers exhibit positive behavioral intentions, including continued patronage and positive word-of-mouth (Kumar et al., 2019; Palmatier et al., 2007). In digital contexts, emotional attachment predicts continued usage and recommendation (Xia et al., 2024; Yum & Kim, 2024). Therefore:

H4: Affective engagement with (a) JOOX Rooms and (b) artists positively influences users' behavioral intentions.

The mediating role of affective engagement

The SOR framework posits that stimuli influence responses through internal organismic states (Jacoby, 2002; Mehrabian & Russell, 1974). Relational bonds should not directly determine behavioral intentions; rather, they first shape users' emotional connections, which then drive behavioral outcomes. Affective engagement serves as the psychological mechanism through which relational bonds translate into loyalty and positive word-of-mouth. Therefore:

H5: Affective engagement with (a) JOOX Rooms and (b) artists mediates the relationship between relational bonds (financial, social, structural) and behavioral intentions.

Figure 1 presents the complete research model with all hypothesized paths.

Material and methods

Case study context: JOOX Rooms

To investigate the research model, we conducted an online survey of JOOX Rooms participants with firsthand experience using the platform. We selected JOOX and JOOX Rooms for several reasons. First, JOOX is a leading digital music platform in Asia, with revenues in the digital music sector continuing to grow significantly. According to recent industry reports, the digital music market in Southeast Asia is projected to reach US$1.2 billion by 2025, with JOOX maintaining a strong market position in Thailand, Indonesia, and Malaysia (Statista, 2024). Second, JOOX was launched in 2015 when digital streaming was in its infancy, and within several years, it achieved promising results, culminating in the launch of JOOX Rooms in January 2022. JOOX Rooms differs from platforms such as Spotify by positioning itself as a multimedia entertainment service focused on promoting engagement between fans and artists (Music Press Asia, 2017). Third, the interactive feature JOOX Rooms delivers varying degrees of relational bonds, providing adequate data for this investigation (Figures 2 and 3).

Questionnaire development

The questionnaire was created in English and translated into Thai for participants. An expert was engaged to ensure translation accuracy and maintain originality in the questions. All measurement items were adapted from prior research with slight modifications to align with the digital music streaming context. A five-point Likert Scale was adopted (1 = 'Strongly Disagree' to 5 = 'Strongly Agree').

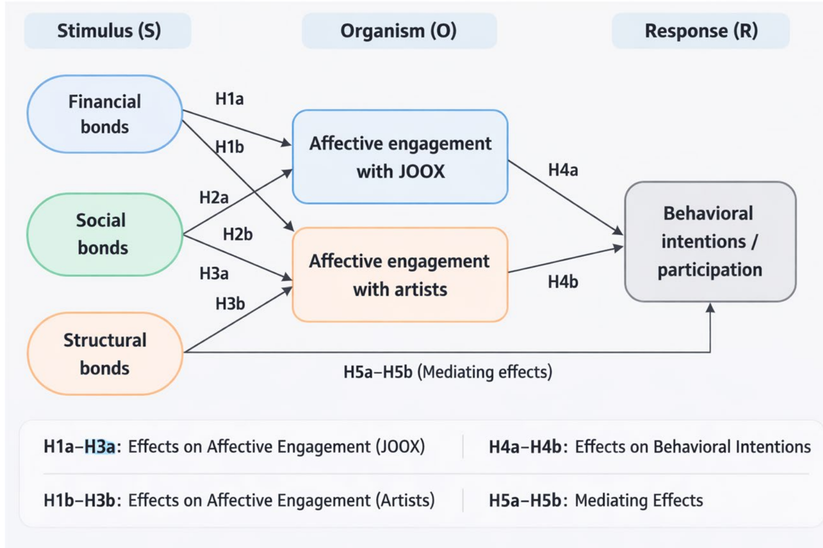

Figure 1. Conceptual Research Model Based on the SOR Framework with Hypothesis Numbers (H1a–H5b). Relational bonds (financial, social, and structural) serve as stimuli (S) influencing affective engagement with JOOX and artists (organism, O), which in turn affects users' behavioral intentions to participate (response, R). H1a–H3a: Effects of relational bonds on affective engagement with JOOX. H1b–H3b: Effects of relational bonds on affective engagement with artists. H4a–H4b: Effects of affective engagement on behavioral intentions. H5a–H5b: Mediating effects of affective engagement.

Table 2 presents all measurement items along with their descriptive statistics and sources. The negatively phrased item 'You don't like artists in JOOX ROOMS' was reverse-coded before analysis.

Data collection

The questionnaire was developed using Survey Monkey and posted on the JOOX Thailand Facebook fan page for access by potential respondents. Data collection occurred from April to May 2024.

Sampling and participants

The target population was defined as males and females living in Thailand who had used the JOOX application and the JOOX Rooms feature. Due to the unknown population size, the researchers determined an appropriate sample size using a confidence level of 95% and a confidence interval of ±7, yielding a target of 205 respondents, assuming normal distribution.

A snowball non-probability sampling technique was employed. Inclusion criteria required that participants be living in Thailand and have used JOOX Rooms within the past four weeks. Questionnaires were distributed through multiple channels: (1) direct distribution on the JOOX Thailand Facebook page, with permission obtained from JOOX Thailand; (2) forwarding of questionnaire links to individuals meeting inclusion criteria, with requests to share; (3) distribution through LINE fan groups; and (4) recruitment via Twitter using the hashtag #JOOX.

A total of 306 individuals initiated the survey. After data cleaning, the final sample comprised 175 complete responses. Data cleaning procedures included: (1) excluding participants who had not used JOOX Rooms (reducing sample to 236), and (2) excluding participants whose age indicated insufficient attention to informed consent (further reducing to 184). Structural equation modeling was conducted only on participants who responded to all relevant items ($N = 175$).

The majority of the sample consisted of women (73%), with an average age of 29.60 years (SD = 7.72). Most participants held a bachelor's degree (76%), followed by master's degree (10%), vocational college (9%), and high school (5%). Private company employees (48%) and university students (24%) comprised most of the sample.

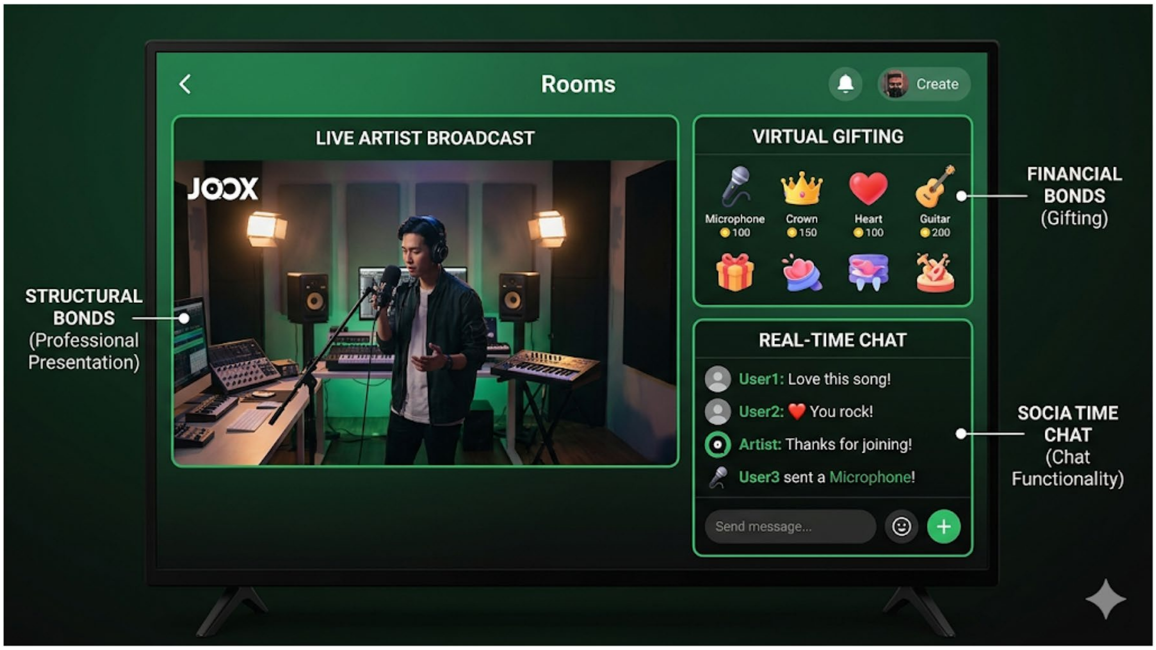

Figure 2. JOOX Rooms interface showing live artist broadcast (left), real-time chat functionality (bottom right), and virtual gifting options (top right). Callouts: The chat box enables social bonds (artist-fan interaction). The gift icon enables financial bonds (virtual gifting). The professional broadcast layout supports structural bonds (reliable, high-quality presentation).

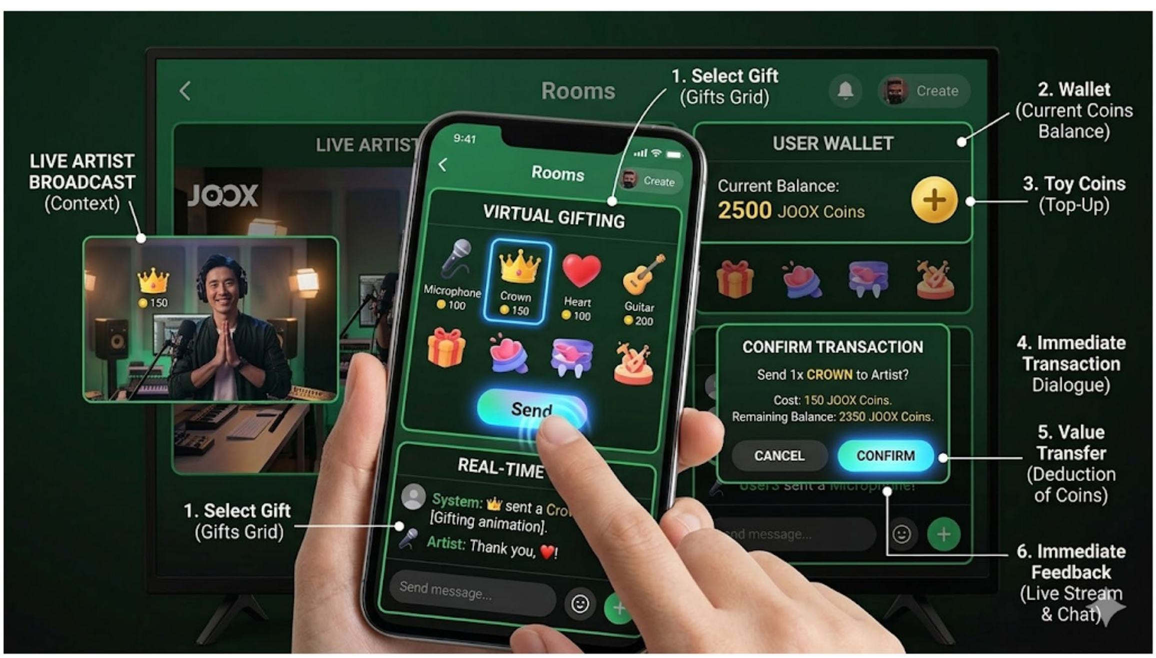

Figure 3. Virtual gifting interface in JOOX Rooms, demonstrating financial bond mechanisms. Users can purchase and send virtual gifts to artists using JOOX Coins. Callout: The gift catalog and coin balance represent the financial incentives that drive transactional engagement.

Ethical considerations

This study was conducted in accordance with the ethical principles outlined in the Declaration of Helsinki. The research protocol was reviewed and approved by the Institutional Review Board (IRB) of Mohammad Ali Jinnah University (MAJU), Karachi, Pakistan (IRB-MAJU/2024/DAF). Participation was voluntary, and

Table 2. Measurement items, descriptive statistics, and sources.

Construct	Item	Min	Max	M	SD	Source
Financial Bonds	Artists offer fans some discounts, like JOOX membership discount codes.	1	5	4.21	0.74	Hsieh et al. (2005); Gu et al. (2016)
	You get a discount if you buy more coins.	1	5	4.22	0.76	
	Artists often give you special incentives, such as special music and gaming rewards.	3	5	4.27	0.74	
	You give coins or gifts to the artists during live broadcasts in JOOX ROOMS.	2	5	4.10	0.84	
Social Bonds	Artists on JOOX ROOMS pay attention to your needs, such as doing what you request, suggesting, and giving them feedback.	2	5	4.23	0.73	Hsieh et al. (2005); Gu et al. (2016)
	During live broadcasts, artists are always interacting with what you type.	2	5	4.18	0.76	
	Artists on JOOX ROOMS often introduce you to interesting or new songs.	3	5	4.25	0.70	
	On a special day, the artists on JOOX ROOMS say their best wishes to you.	1	5	4.19	0.79	
Structural Bonds	Artists in JOOX ROOMS answer your questions professionally.	2	5	4.26	0.72	Chiu et al. (2005)
	You receive a quick response when you encounter problems or have complaints.	2	5	4.14	0.71	
	You are clearly informed about the song.	2	5	4.18	0.68	
	You receive useful information about music to help increase your listening pleasure.	2	5	4.31	0.71	
Affective Engagement - Artists	You feel that you can trust the artists in JOOX ROOMS.	2	5	4.37	0.71	Wongkitrungrueng and Assarut (2020); Tsai and Men (2013)
	You are attached to the artists in JOOX ROOMS.	2	5	4.14	0.71	
	You don't like artists in JOOX ROOMS. (R)	1	5	2.33	1.25	
	You enjoy listening to live music and chatting with artists on JOOX ROOMS.	3	5	4.17	0.75	
Affective Engagement - JOOX	You feel that you can trust JOOX ROOMS.	3	5	4.39	0.63	Wongkitrungrueng and Assarut (2020); Tsai and Men (2013)
	You are attached to JOOX ROOMS.	2	5	4.27	0.70	
	You like how JOOX ROOMS work.	3	5	4.30	0.68	
Behavioral Intentions	You will continue to use JOOX ROOMS.	3	5	4.52	0.64	Adapted from consumer behavior literature
	Soon, you will purchase any product or service sold through JOOX ROOMS.	2	5	4.31	0.74	
	You are likely to recommend JOOX ROOMS to your friends.	2	5	4.36	0.70	

Note: (R) denotes reverse-coded item. Means and SDs are based on original coding; reverse-coded values were used in all analyses.

informed written consent was obtained electronically from all participants. The consent form outlined the study's purpose, question nature, time commitment, and confidentiality. Participants were informed of their right to withdraw without penalty. All data were anonymized and aggregated; no personally identifiable information was stored.

Analytical procedure

Data were analyzed using R (R Core Team, 2024). Primary analyses followed structural equation modeling principles (Kline, 2015). In the first step, we formed and tested the model fit according to established criteria. Only when the model fit was acceptable did we interpret estimates.

Results

Measurement model

We first computed a complete measurement model including all constructs. Fit indices indicated acceptable fit (robust CFI = 0.914, robust RMSEA = 0.066 [0.053, 0.079], SRMR = 0.060). However, a Heywood case was reported as a negative variance of the participation construct. Examination of model-implied correlations (Table 3) revealed an explanation: the near-singular relationship between affective engagement with JOOX and affective engagement with artists (r = 0.89) indicated multicollinearity, which may have led to unrealistic parameter estimates.

Based on this finding, we concluded that affective engagement with artists did not meaningfully contribute to the model beyond affective engagement with JOOX. Consequently, we excluded affective engagement with artists from subsequent analyses. This decision means that H1b, H2b, H3b, H4b, and H5b could not be tested. This finding itself is theoretically significant, suggesting that in the JOOX Rooms context, users' emotional engagement with artists is empirically inseparable from their engagement with the platform.

Additionally, we observed multicollinearity among the three motive constructs (VIF values ranging from 3.2 to 5.1). Therefore, we formed a second-order factor of motives to ensure that high intercorrelations did not bias estimates.

Hypothesis testing

The final model (Figure 4) exhibited acceptable fit (robust CFI = 0.919, robust RMSEA = 0.069 [0.053, 0.084], SRMR = 0.059). We tested hypotheses by examining path coefficients and indirect effects.

H1a: Financial Bonds → Affective Engagement with JOOX

The path from financial bonds to affective engagement with JOOX was positive and significant (β = .86, $p < 0.001$). **H1a is supported.**

H2a: Social Bonds → Affective Engagement with JOOX

The path from social bonds to affective engagement with JOOX was positive and significant (β = .95, $p < 0.001$). **H2a is supported.**

H3a: Structural Bonds → Affective Engagement with JOOX

The path from structural bonds to affective engagement with JOOX was positive and significant (β = .98, $p < 0.001$). **H3a is supported.**

H4a: Affective Engagement with JOOX → Behavioral Intentions

The path from affective engagement with JOOX to behavioral intentions was positive and significant (β = .97, $p < 0.001$). **H4a is supported.**

H5a: Mediating Role of Affective Engagement with JOOX

To test mediation, we examined direct, indirect, and total effects:

- Direct path from motives to behavioral intentions: $\beta = -0.02$, $p = .906$ (non-significant)
- Indirect path from motives to behavioral intentions via affective engagement: $\beta = 0.81$, $p < .001$ (significant)

Table 3. Model-implied correlations.

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
(1) Financial Motives	(0.67)					
(2) Social Motives	0.84	(0.73)				
(3) Structural Motives	0.79	0.94	(0.76)			
(4) Affective Engagement - Artist	0.86	0.82	0.83	(0.64)		
(5) Affective Engagement - JOOX	0.79	0.74	0.83	0.89	(0.82)	
(6) Behavioral Intentions	0.72	0.70	0.77	0.71	0.94	(0.90)

Note: All $p < .001$. Diagonal contains internal consistency estimates (ω). The correlation of 0.89 between affective engagement with artists and affective engagement with JOOX indicates multicollinearity. Variance Inflation Factor (VIF) values exceeded 5.0 for these constructs, confirming problematic multicollinearity.

- Total path from motives to behavioral intentions: $\beta=0.79$, $p < .001$ (significant)

The exhibited descriptive data in Table 1 suggest that participants scored very high on each of the key items of this study. In other words, participants, on average, exhibited a strong presence of financial, social, and structural motives, as well as strong affective engagement with artists and JOOX, and strong intentions to continue using JOOX and recommend it to friends.

These results indicate **full mediation**: motives affect behavioral intentions entirely through affective engagement with JOOX. **H5a is supported.**

Discussion

Consistent with our hypotheses, all three types of relational bonds positively influenced users' affective engagement with the JOOX platform. Financial bonds, including JOOX Coins, membership discounts, and gaming rewards, provided tangible value that generated positive emotional associations. Social bonds, facilitated by real-time chat, artist responsiveness, and personalized interactions, fulfilled needs for connection and recognition, fostering parasocial relationships. Structural bonds, including professional responses, technical support, and information curation, built trust and reliability, creating emotional attachment to the platform itself.

Affective engagement with JOOX strongly predicted behavioral intentions, including continued use and recommendation. Most importantly, affective engagement fully mediated the relationship between relational bonds and behavioral intentions, confirming the SOR framework's core proposition: external stimuli influence behavioral outcomes through their impact on internal emotional states.

The non-significant role of affective engagement with artists

A notable finding emerged regarding affective engagement with artists. Due to extreme multicollinearity ($r=0.89$) with affective engagement with JOOX, this construct was excluded from the final model. This suggests that in the JOOX Rooms context, users do not meaningfully distinguish between their emotional connection to the platform and their connection to the artists on it. This finding has important theoretical implications.

One interpretation is that the platform itself becomes so integral to the fan-artist relationship that the two objects of engagement merge in users' minds. JOOX Rooms is not merely a neutral medium through which fans access artists; it actively shapes the nature and quality of those interactions. Platform studies scholarship emphasizes that platforms are not passive conduits but active agents that structure relationships, govern interactions, and shape user experiences (Gillespie, 2018; Plantin

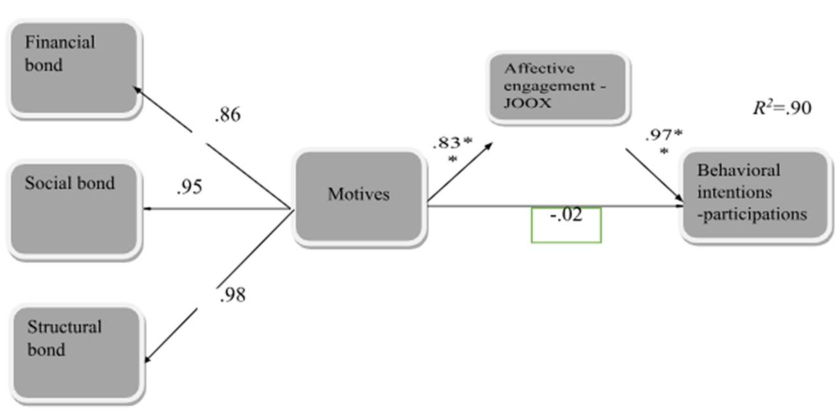

Figure 4. Final structural model with second-order motives factor and affective engagement with JOOX as mediator. Standardized path coefficients shown. ***$p<0.001$.

et al., 2018). In this view, JOOX Rooms co-constitutes the fan-artist relationship rather than simply facilitating it.

Another interpretation draws on fan studies research, which recognizes that contemporary fan culture is increasingly platform-mediated (Baym, 2018; Click & Scott, 2025). Fans' emotional investments are distributed across artists, fan communities, and the platforms that enable connection. The platform becomes part of the fan experience, not just a technical infrastructure but a social and emotional space. When fans feel attached to JOOX Rooms, they may be experiencing attachment to the entire ecosystem of relationships with artists, with other fans, and with the platform itself, which the platform enables.

Extending platform studies and fan studies

Our finding that platform and artist engagement are empirically inseparable extends platform studies in a novel direction. Prior platform scholarship (Gillespie, 2018; Plantin et al., 2018) has argued that platforms actively shape user behavior, but our results suggest an even stronger claim: in deeply integrated environments like JOOX Rooms, the platform becomes a constitutive element of the fan-artist relationship, not merely a mediator. Users do not experience the platform as a separate entity from the artist; rather, the platform *is* the relationship space. This challenges assumptions in platform studies that distinguish platform infrastructure from social interactions, indicating that for users, these may be cognitively fused.

From a fan studies perspective (Baym, 2018; Click & Scott, 2025), our findings suggest that platform-mediated parasocial interactions generate attachment not only to artists but also to the platform ecosystem. This raises new questions about fan agency and platform dependency. If fans cannot easily distinguish their love for an artist from their loyalty to the platform, then platform switching becomes emotionally costly—a form of lock-in that operates at the psychological level.

Qualitatively different forms of affective engagement

Our results also indicate that different relational bonds may generate qualitatively different forms of affective engagement. Financial bonds (eg JOOX Coins, discounts) appear to produce *transactional attachment*, engagement based on perceived value and reciprocity. Social bonds (eg real-time chat, personalized wishes) generate *parasocial attachment*, emotional closeness to artists. Structural bonds (eg professional responses, reliable streaming) build *trust-based attachment*, confidence in the platform as a dependable service.

While all three contributed positively to overall affective engagement, practitioners should recognize that each bond type serves a distinct psychological function. A platform that relies solely on financial incentives may achieve short-term engagement but lacks the depth of social or structural bonds. Conversely, strong social bonds without structural reliability may lead to frustration when technical issues arise. The synergy among bond types is therefore essential.

Unique contributions to each field

To clearly articulate our contributions:

- **To relationship marketing**: We extend Berry's (1995) relational bonds framework to live streaming music platforms, demonstrating full mediation through affective engagement and revealing empirical inseparability of platform and artist attachment.
- **To platform studies**: We provide quantitative evidence that users' emotional attachment to a platform can be empirically indistinguishable from attachment to content creators, suggesting platforms co-constitute relationships rather than merely mediating them.
- **To fan studies**: We show how platform features (chat, gifting, professional responses) shape parasocial interactions in live streaming contexts, and how these interactions produce dual attachments to both artists and the platform.

Theoretical implications

This study makes several theoretical contributions. First, it extends relationship marketing literature to the digital music streaming context, demonstrating that Berry's (1995) three types of relational bonds remain relevant and effective in contemporary digital environments. However, our findings suggest that the boundaries between these bond types may blur in practice, as financial, social, and structural features work synergistically to create holistic user experiences.

Second, the study validates the SOR framework as a useful lens for understanding user engagement on digital platforms. By demonstrating full mediation through affective engagement, we provide empirical support for the framework's core proposition that stimuli influence responses through internal organismic states. This contributes to ongoing efforts to apply SOR in digital contexts (Hou et al., 2024; Xia et al., 2024; Yum & Kim, 2024).

Third, the study contributes to platform studies by demonstrating empirically that users develop emotional attachments to platforms themselves, not just to the content or people accessed through them. The multicollinearity between artist and platform engagement suggests that in deeply integrated digital environments, these attachments may become inseparable. This supports theoretical arguments that platforms are not neutral intermediaries but active participants in cultural production and social relationships (Gillespie, 2018; Plantin et al., 2018).

Fourth, the study contributes to fan studies by showing how platform features shape fan-artist relationships. The parasocial interactions theorized by Horton and Wohl (1956) take on new forms in live streaming contexts, where interactivity and immediacy create unprecedented intimacy. However, this intimacy is always platform-mediated, raising questions about platform power and fan agency that warrant further investigation (Baym, 2018; Click & Scott, 2025).

Practical implications

For digital music streaming platforms, our findings suggest several strategies for enhancing user engagement:

1. **Invest in multiple bond types**: Platforms should develop financial, social, and structural bonds simultaneously, as each contributes uniquely to affective engagement. Financial incentives alone may create transactional loyalty, but social and structural bonds build deeper emotional connections.
2. **Design for platform attachment**: Given that affective engagement with the platform itself drives behavioral intentions, platforms should focus on creating positive experiences with the platform interface, not just facilitating artist relationships. Features that enhance usability, reliability, and enjoyment contribute directly to platform attachment.
3. **Leverage parasocial interaction**: Social bonds that enable perceived intimacy with artists are powerful drivers of engagement. Platforms should design features that facilitate authentic artist-fan interaction, including real-time communication and personalized recognition.
4. **Build trust through structural bonds**: Professional responses, prompt support, and reliable service build trust, which is a fundamental component of affective engagement. Platforms should invest in infrastructure and training that ensures consistent, high-quality user experiences.
5. **Recognize platform-artist synergy**: Because users may not distinguish between platform and artist attachment, platforms should collaborate with artists to create cohesive experiences. Artist presence enhances platform value, and platform quality enhances artist accessibility.

Conclusion

This study examined how relational bonds influence affective engagement and behavioral intentions on JOOX Rooms, a digital music streaming platform in Thailand. Drawing on the SOR framework, we found that financial, social, and structural bonds positively influence affective engagement with the platform, which in turn drives behavioral intentions to continue using and recommend the service. Notably, affective engagement with artists was empirically indistinguishable from platform engagement, suggesting that the platform itself becomes integral to fan-artist relationships in deeply mediated environments.

The study contributes to relationship marketing, platform studies, and fan studies by demonstrating the mechanisms through which platform features generate emotional attachment and behavioral loyalty. For practitioners, the findings highlight the importance of investing in multiple bond types and designing for platform attachment.

Limitations and future research

First, the snowball sampling technique limits generalizability, as the sample may over-represent highly engaged users who are more likely to participate in fan communities and forward surveys. Heavy users may have stronger affective engagement and more positive behavioral intentions than casual users, potentially inflating the observed relationships. Future research should employ probability sampling or quota sampling to confirm these findings across broader populations, including lighter users and non-fan community members.

Second, the study was conducted in Thailand, a distinct cultural context. Cultural values may influence how relational bonds operate and how users develop affective engagement (Hofstede, 2005). Cross-cultural comparative studies would illuminate whether these findings generalize across regions.

Third, the cross-sectional design captures relationships at a single point in time. Longitudinal research could examine how affective engagement develops over time and whether the relative importance of different bond types changes with user experience.

Fourth, the study focused on a single platform, JOOX Rooms. Comparative studies across platforms (eg Spotify, Apple Music, YouTube Music) could identify which features are platform-specific versus generalizable across digital music services.

Fifth, the inability to test hypotheses involving artist engagement raises questions about the distinctiveness of platform versus artist attachment. Future research should investigate this relationship more deeply, perhaps using experimental designs that manipulate platform features to isolate their effects.

Sixth, future research should explore additional moderators, such as user characteristics (eg fan identity strength, prior platform experience) and contextual factors (eg genre of music, artist popularity), that may influence the relationships identified here.

Finally, interdisciplinary approaches integrating marketing, platform studies, fan studies, and algorithm studies could provide richer understanding of how technical infrastructures, cultural practices, and emotional attachments interact in digital entertainment environments.

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Author contributions

CRediT: **Smith Boonchutima**: Data curation, Project administration, Supervision, Validation, Visualization, Writing – review & editing; **Nattawee Chanapun**: Conceptualization, Data curation, Formal analysis, Investigation, Methodology, Software, Validation, Writing – original draft; **Ibtesam Mazahir**: Validation, Visualization, Writing – original draft, Writing – review & editing.

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Data availability statement

The data will be made available on reasonable request to the corresponding authors.

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